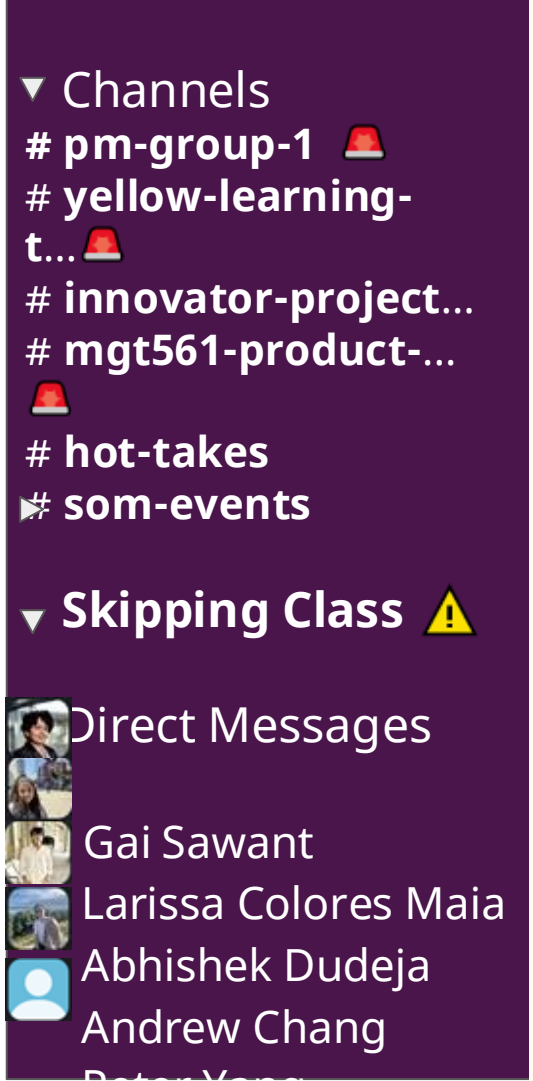


Slack
Intelligent Notifications

Urgent, Relevant, Automatic

Return to office mandates drive demand for innovative “Future of Work” solutions, prioritizing productivity and delightful customer experience

Company

Salesforce is a cloud-based software company that provides a suite of tools for customer relationship management and that acquired Slack in 2021

Product

Slack is a communications platform designed for organizations, offering messaging, files sharing, integration with several tools and automation of workflows. Slack helps teams to be connected, and experienced significant growth with the increasing adoption of remorse working

Future of Work

- Many companies embraced remote working during the pandemic
- Slack customer base growth accelerated, playing a key role in enabling remote work
- As many organizations face a return to office mandate or a shift to hybrid working models, Slack must adapt to ensure its success
- Specifically, Slack can help bridge the gap between remote and in-person work environments by streamlining communications

As the future of work continues to evolve, tools like Slack will play a crucial role in enabling remote and hybrid work models, supporting collaboration, and enhancing overall productivity

Customer surveys & interviews unearthed key pain points – specifically, in searching for messages or clearing overloaded notifications – even for large, premium Slack users

The Intelligent Notifications feature addresses key pain points that will be exacerbated by return to office shifts

- **Search & Organisation Issues**
  - Users struggle to find past messages, files, and announcements due to Slack's limited search and cluttered threads
- **Notification Overload**
  - A key pain point is lack of intelligent notification management, causing users to get overwhelmed and lose track of high priority messages

We identified and validated this problem through extensive customer research

- **User Interviews and UGC analysis**
  - Gathering insights from diverse user groups and UGC helped identify these insights
- **Real-Life Use Cases**
  - People shared specific examples of their concerns with Slack right now, especially compared to other platforms

Example Persona & Customer Journey

- **Persona:**
  - Large company with premium plans and high customization needs, such as Cisco or Crowdstrike

- **Customer Journey:**
  - The user struggles to stay on top of their Slack backlog due to notification overload.
  - They miss key messages, especially when they are in the office.
  - They waste time searching for specific information within cluttered Slack channels and threads.
  - These inefficiencies leads to decreased productivity and lower satisfaction with Slack.

Our goal is to serve the Advanced user segment by delivering a feature that boosts their efficiency in responding to Slack messages while working in the office.

TAM	• Approximately 20M advanced users in the U.S. are on premium plans and are employed at large orgs
Opportunity Size	• Largest opportunity size ($51M), higher than Intermediate and Basic User segments • Highest willingness to pay, largest revenue potential
Competition	• The competition in Advanced User segment indicates it is an attractive market. • New features provide opportunities for differentiation and standing out.
Demand for Advanced Features	• Advanced users have demand for advanced features, in areas including workflow, notification, integration, and automation.

Strategic Alignment	• We aim to deliver a positive impact on user retention and monetization within our core segment, especially as business needs and workforce dynamics to evolve with RTO policies:
	  ○ The feature helps prevent churn by keeping Slack essential to workplace communication
	  ○ It can unlock a new stream of income by being offered as a paid add-on for existing clients who have implemented or are planning to implement RTO policies

We selected requirements that deliver value to target users without introducing substantial development complexity

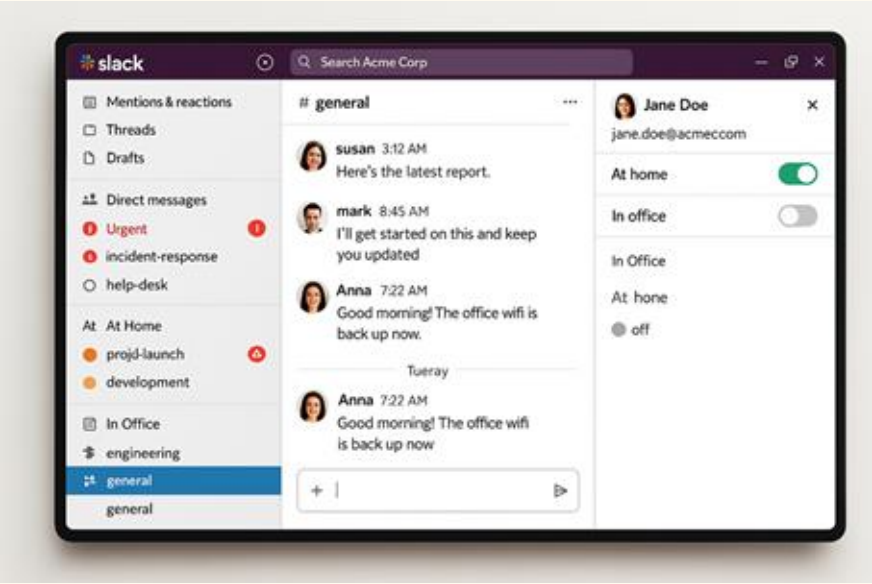
Must Have

1. Turn on an "in-the-office" status, initiating the feature prioritization process
2. Ability to turn off the feature (through menu or toggle)
3. Mechanism (algorithmic or manual) to define the "high priority" messages
4. Different UX for high priority messages: segregation via a different section on sidebar or color coding

Nice to Have (not in the MVP scope)

1. Set up automatic message to answer not prioritized messages
2. Custom rules to redirect high priority messages to reporting manager or team lead in the absence of the individual

MVP Mockup:



The must-have requirements tackle the challenge of notification prioritization during in-office work without significantly increasing the complexity of MVP development

Solving Notification Overload for High-Value, Advanced Slack Users

General User	*"There are too many Slack features."*	Easy to turn feature on-off as per need.
Hybrid Worker	*"When I'm WFH, it's harder to tell what's urgent or being discussed in person. It's also hard to track down my teammates."*	Context-aware prioritization surfaces important messages more clearly when WFH & highlights your messages in-turn.
Cross - Functional Collaborator	*"I'm spread across many teams and channels. I often miss important updates because of volume, not intent."*	Flags high-priority messages using sender importance, channel history, and keywords; shows them in a dedicated sidebar.
Manager / Team Lead	*"I need urgent messages escalated when a team member is OOO, without chasing them down."*	Auto-redirect rules and escalation options for high-priority messages when the recipient is unavailable

How We'll Measure Impact: Metrics, Signals, and their Importance

Category	Metric	Target/Threshold
Primary	Median Message Read Latency	< 28.8 mins median latency
	Average Unread Notifications	< 11.9 unread messages at EOD
Secondary	CSAT / Prioritization Feedback	≥60% positive feedback
	Complaint Rate	<25% increase in tickets from baseline
Guardrail	WFH Toggle Usage	<20% toggle use (min 1 day/week)
	Opt-Out Rate	>30% opt-out
	Message Volume Drop	>10% volume drop per User

- Aligned with Activation and Retention stages of Slack's AAARR funnel
- Focused on responsiveness, satisfaction, and engagement
- Designed for hybrid & RTO users, critical to Slack's future growth
- Support Slack's OKRs: Improved productivity & user satisfaction

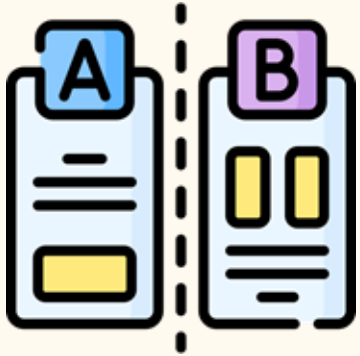
Evaluation Framework: Hypotheses for Feature Adoption, Impact, and User Response

Outcome	Success Criteria
Message Responsiveness	**H1**: >10% faster median message-read latency vs control **H0**: ≤10% improvement
Notification Overload	**H1**: >15% reduction in unread messages after 24 hrs **H0**: ≤15% decrease or no significant change
User Sentiment	**H1**: No increase or net decrease in complaints/support tickets **H0**: ≥10% increase
Feature Adoption	**H1**: ≥30% of test users opt in & engage weekly **H0**: <30% opt-in or irregular use

Experiment Setup: Testing Notification Features with Power Users

A/B Testing

- Salesforce employees who match our “advanced” Slack user persona (in a large number of channels or receive a high volume of messages daily, and who have a mix of WFH and in-office days)
  - **Control Group (500 users)**: Continue using the standard Slack app
  - **Treatment Group (500 users)**: Use Slack with the new Intelligent Notification system installed
- Randomize at user level, minimize selection bias
  - Each group has similar distribution of message volume, roles, and work patterns, and falls in the median range of advanced users



Risks

- Initial usage may not be reflective of long term adoption i.e novelty effect
- To reduce biases, overlap with other beta testing efforts and dogfooding must be minimised for the group in consideration
- External events such as quarterly planning, critical incidents, or company-wide reorgs can lead to misleading observations owing to a change in notification flow